

JAPAN

JAPAN IS A CHAIN OF SOME 4,000 ISLANDS stretching for more than 1,553 miles (2,500 km) off the east coast of mainland Asia. Most people live on the four largest islands – Honshu, Hokkaido, Shikoku, and Kyushu. Flat land is in short supply. More than three-quarters of the country is hilly, leaving less than a quarter suitable for building and farming. To create more level ground, hillsides are being cut back and land is being reclaimed from the sea. Japan's climate is a varied one. The islands in the south are warm all year round, while in the north it is cooler, with snowfall on the mountains in winter. The Japanese call their country *Nippon*, "the land of the rising Sun," since the Sun can be seen rising above the Pacific Ocean.

THE EMPEROR

Japan has the oldest hereditary monarchy in the world, dating back to before the 6th century. In the past, the emperor was very powerful and many Japanese people believed he was a god. But the emperor's status changed after Japan's defeat in World War II, and his role was reduced to a symbolic one.

The present emperor, Akihito, is the 125th in the imperial line. He is highly respected by Japanese people, but he has no political power.



Mount Fuji is a huge, cone-shaped volcano. It last erupted in 1707.



ISLAND LINKS

Travel between the islands is made easier by a network of bridges and tunnels linking them together. The Seto Ohashi Bridge (above) connects several of the smaller islands. The Akashi Kaikyo Road Bridge, linking Honshu and Shikoku, opened in 1998. It is the world's longest suspension bridge, with an overall span of 6,529 ft (1,990 m).



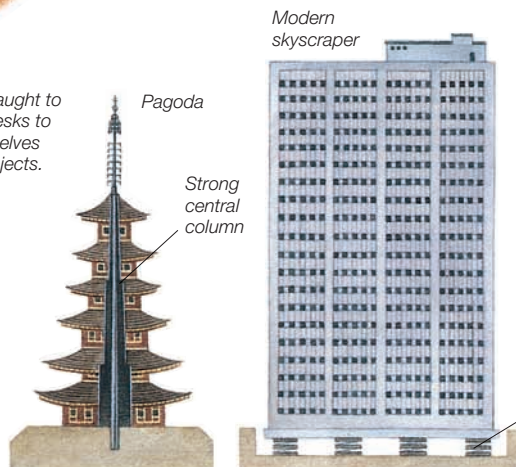
Children are taught to duck under desks to protect themselves from falling objects.

UNSTABLE LAND

Japan suffers from hundreds of earthquakes a year. Slight shakes are recorded almost every day, while larger tremors causing minor damage can be felt several times a year. Strong earthquakes occur more rarely, causing damage, injury, and death. Buildings and bridges topple, roads and railroads are destroyed, and devastating fires break out. In 1995, a massive earthquake struck the port of Kobe and killed more than 5,000 people. Regular earthquake drills are held in schools, homes, and workplaces.

SACRED MOUNTAIN

At 12,388 ft (3,776 m), Mount Fuji, on Honshu, is Japan's highest mountain. For the followers of Shinto, one of Japan's major religions, Mount Fuji is a sacred mountain. Each year, thousands of pilgrims make the long climb to visit the Shinto shrine on the summit. Many Japanese consider Mount Fuji to be a symbol of their country and keep a photograph or painting of the mountain on display in their homes.



BUILT TO LAST

Both new and old buildings in Japan have been designed with earthquakes in mind. A pagoda has a strong central column sunk into the ground to give it added stability. A modern skyscraper has a regular shape and thick walls reinforced by steel columns, which help make the building more secure.

Skyscrapers are often built on pads made of steel and rubber that absorb earthquake tremors.